

105 years

SHARFUDDIN QUADRI

Unani practitioner, Kolkata

His day begins at 7 in the evening. His patients crowd around the tiny Swadeshi Dawakhana that he runs in central Kolkata. A lane that his patients (he treats for free) have been clogging up every evening for the last 75 years. "They'll come till 1.30 in the morning," says the city's oldest unani medicine practitioner. Around two in the morning, he goes for his walks along the sleepy streets and returns home only at 6 in the morning. Hakim Saheb never wakes up before noon and sustains himself on two cups of "laal cha" and one frugal meal a day—a roti or a small bowl of rice. "I have so much work that I end up not eating anything for nearly 15 days a month". Truly, he has done a lot in one lifetime. He participated in the Dandi March, was jailed in Cuttack as a freedom fighter, learnt the sitar for 14 years from ustads Wazir Khan and Inayat Khan, discovered over 40 unani medicines and founded the city's only unani medical college. He looks like the friendly old wizard he is, but no one would believe he was born on December 25, 1901, unless they saw his Padma Bhushan citation from the President of India. Ask him if he considers his life fruitful and he recites Tagore: "*Moron jedin ashbey tomar dwarey, shedin ki diye pujibey tarey?*" (When death comes to your doorstep, what will you worship him with?).

by Swagata Sen

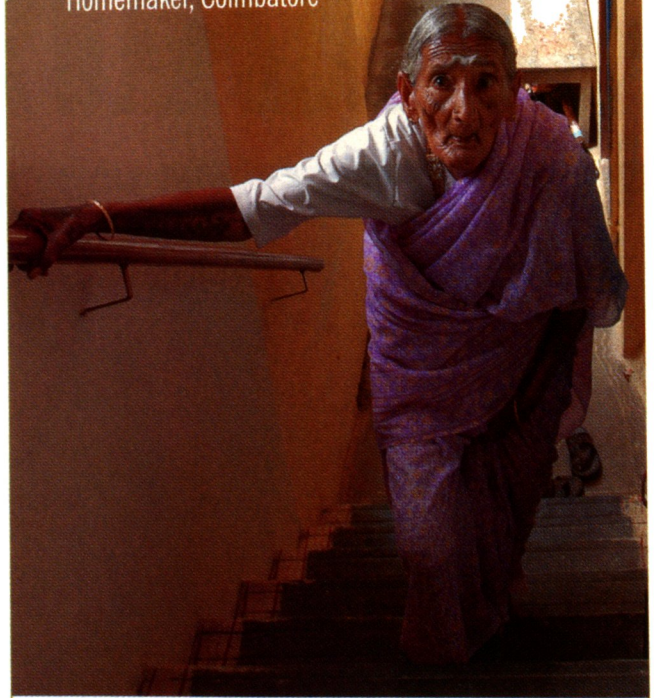


SUBASHISH MALIK

109 years

THAYAMMA

Homemaker, Coimbatore



"I do all my work myself. I don't rely on anyone to do anything for me," says Thayamma of Coimbatore. Every day, she wakes at 5.30 a.m.

and sets out for a brisk walk ("No, I don't need a walking stick. There's nothing wrong with me except my hearing.") and is back by six to prepare a cup of coffee for herself and her breakfast—three idlis or dosas. She then washes her clothes ("I'm fussy about cleanliness"), grinds the idly-dosa dough in an unwieldy hand-grinder ("Even my eldest daughter, 80, finds it tough") and cooks lunch ("I like making my own food."). Lunch at 12.30 is a doctor's delight: two cups of rice, green vegetables and an egg. Two hours of napping, tea at 4.30 and Thyamma is out again for a walk. After dinner at eight—three chapattis and a cup of milk—she drifts off. Active life and frugal diet hold the key to her long life.

Thayamma has seen five generations—116 people. Her husband, a cotton merchant, died 30 years ago. Of her 10 children, her eldest daughter is 80. But Thyamma is more fit than her. She walks with a spring in her steps and climbs up and down the stairs without effort. "When my mother feels lonely she calls us over. Otherwise there is no problem at all from her side," says Jayabal, her tenth son, born when she was in her 50s. Thyamma, by the way, has never been to a hospital. What does she wish for? "All my children, grandchildren and great grandchildren are doing fine. I don't have any wishes left. Only a peaceful death."

by Lakshmi Subramaniam